

Winning at technology itself

The New Year is here and apart from resolutions, it is also a time for cheap introspection and armchair theorising. I wouldn't want to disappoint anyone, so here goes. After six years in the technology-media business, I am a part of the 'Tech Media Frat Boys Club', a ragtag group of technology writers who have or are currently working with big-name brands (such as *Digit*).

So, okay, we're not exactly a secret coven. We actually meet up quite openly (and often too boisterously) in establishments of less repute and discuss, among other things, technology, the street-light effect (look it up, it's a real thing), and beer (not necessarily in that order).

At some point, the conversation always takes a whimsical turn (no points for guessing when) and in one of our recent conclaves someone ended up asking this question, "What phone would you buy if you had an unlimited amount of money?". Seemingly innocuous, this question actually sent me off on a thinking tizzy. What exactly would be the deciding factor in such a situation? Technology? Innovation? Innovative technology? My comrades bandied about the usual suspects (Sony Xperia Z3, iPhone 6 Plus, HTC One M8), but when my turn came, I said I was perfectly happy with my Nexus 5, since there was nothing that I couldn't do with my Nexus 5 that I'd be able to with those phones. There's very little difference at the top end – choices at this level are not really driven by innovation – they are purely consumeristic (iSwear).

Long after the bacchanalian discussion was over, consumerism, technology, and innovation continued to swirl around in my head. What is true innovation really? It's certainly not this "incremental innovation" we see all around us today. It's easy to be dazzled by large-screen TVs, drones, 3D printers, and even our handy, almost magical, smartphones. These creations seemed impossible even a few decades ago and one might argue that we are at the pinnacle of technology. But this is simply not true.

We have had at least two golden eras of true innovation. The industrial revolution, followed by the age of electrification, led to unforeseen advances in manufacturing and transportation. The period, from the end of the second world war (1945) up to the Watergate scandal (early 70s), saw huge achievements such as the moon landing, the invention of micro electronics, computers, civil aviation, television, and antibiotics. To use Google's phrase, all these are examples of "moonshot thinking" – these were good solid innovations, nothing remotely 'incremental' about them.

Science author Michael Hanlon calls this period "The Golden Quarter". He believes we stopped truly innovating since then, and I agree. Take an example of mass transportation over great distances. In the 1950s, the best passenger liners took four days for a transatlantic voyage. With international civil aviation taking off (mostly in the 70s with the jumbo jet), the travel time fell to just 8 hours. By that same progression, by now we should have had a mass-transport system that takes us across the Atlantic in just 40 minutes! There are many such examples that show that technological innovation is stagnating – by now we should have been commuting to the moon, landed on Mars, and cured cancer. Tyler Cowen, in his 2011 essay, *The Great Stagnation*, talks about how America harvested the "low-hanging fruit" of technological innovation and is slowing down due to a lack of true innovation.

But why have we stopped innovating? As it turns out, my jab at consumerism is far closer to the truth than I'd like. Money, whether it's shareholder wealth or venture capital, is only flowing to companies that are able to post growth on their financial statements. And one of the surest ways of doing this is by planned obsolescence and creating a market for 'incrementally' better products with high aspirational value. It's the safest bet. Why bother pouring money into R&D for a hoverboard? Of course, the problem isn't as simple nor as isolated as consumerism. The topic is too vast and multifaceted to be discussed in an editorial (involving factors like philanthropic funding for research, government will, lack of motivation, war climate, etc.).

Coming back to matters at hand – in this issue of *Digit* you'll find a ton of things you could do to win at everything *using* technology. With this editorial I'm trying to address the need to win at technology itself. Thankfully, there are stalwarts such as Elon Musk (almost a real-life Tony Stark) who are truly innovating, not just for wealth creation, but for innovation itself. His Hyperloop concept, the open sourcing of Tesla patents, SpaceX, are being closely watched and in the coming year, and through my life, I fervently hope for innovation, big or small, especially from India. On that note here's wishing you a happy new year and a chance at winning *for*, *with*, and *at* technology! 🇮🇳



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